

A Transportation Transformation

In the northeastern United States, from Independence (1776) until the Civil War (1861-1865), state and local governments, rather than the federal (national) government, were the sources of most initiatives to improve transportation, although private entrepreneurs were the principal builders of toll roads in the early nineteenth century. All toll roads required payment for use, but few toll roads were profitable, and improvements in water transportation made greater contributions to commerce and economy. The use of steamships on rivers from the second and third decades of the nineteenth century reduced the cost and increased the speed of transporting goods up such major rivers as the Hudson, Ohio, Mississippi, and Missouri and contributed to the growth of cities such as Albany, St. Louis, Cincinnati, Louisville, and Pittsburgh. Since there were over twenty thousand miles of navigable rivers in the pre-Civil War United States, the fuller use of natural inland waterways was a major step in integrating the new nation. Steamships soon lowered transport rates on large lakes, along the sea coasts, and in international trade.

Failing to obtain federal aid, New York State, with help from British investors, financed the 363-mile Erie Canal. The canal opened in 1825 and linked Buffalo on Lake Erie with Troy and Albany on the Hudson River and thus with the Atlantic Ocean. The Erie Canal lowered transportation costs from Buffalo to New York City by 90 percent and established New York City as the premier United States port. The canal that linked the Ohio river with Lake Erie in 1833 was another example of connecting major waterways and large regions with each other. Nearly four thousand miles of canals were operating by the 1850s, with three-quarters of the financing coming from state and local governments, borrowed mostly from British investors.

The principal canal networks connected the Northeastern Seaboard with the Upper Midwest. The low cost of canal and steamboat shipping made it feasible to convey even bulky, low-priced goods long distances. This put northeastern and Mid-Atlantic grain farmers at a competitive disadvantage in respect to grain from the rich soils of the Ohio River valley and beyond. The beleaguered farmers had to switch to dairying or vegetable and fruit crops to remain viable, but instead they

often left farming or migrated west New England farmers were most likely to migrate, and recurrent sightings of stone walls in deep New England forests are modern-day reminders of those abandoned farms.

The canals were successful, but then came the railroads. The first railroad in the United States-the Baltimore and Ohio-opened in 1830 with a locomotive imported from Great Britain. Thirty years later, the United States boasted over thirty thousand miles of tracks with a total expenditure five times greater than that invested in canal construction. Like the canals, most railroad lines were located in the northern regions of the nation and facilitated east-west transport, and Chicago, with four thousand miles of track converging there by 1860, became one of the major transportation hubs. Rail competition led to the closure of many transportation canals and the cancellation of new canal projects.

Railroads were more flexible than canals because they could move goods and people over a variety of terrains with fewer problems posed by mountains, water levels, freezing weather, and trans shipments. They reduced overland travel time by about thirty times, and it was the greater speed that made rail travel attractive to people. But railroad freight (shipped goods) revenue exceeded passenger revenue by the end of the 1850s, also the point when the volume of freight sent by rail surpassed that of canals. River transport continued to be widely used

The telegraph was a spectacular change in communication. It complemented the expansion of the railroads by enabling railroads to coordinate and monitor schedules. The railroad companies often allowed a telegraph company to string lines along railroads' rights of way in exchange for discounted service fees.

There were over fifty telegraph companies in the early 1850s when a group of Rochester, New York. businessmen began consolidating small companies into what became Western Union (a famous telegraph company). This consolidation led to better efficiencies and improved service, facilitating the increased use of telegraph service for money orders, business news, newspaper reporting, personal messages, and conduct of war. Western Union completed the first coast-to-coast line across the nation in 1861, leading the United States Post Office to cancel the Pony Express (mail delivery by riders on horseback) when the Civil War began.

